large enterprise. He was only the MD of his family enterprise whose turnover was around 3 per cent that of the Tatas at the time of his selection.

In addition, Mistry was also taking over from the legendary Ratan who had worked in the group since the age of twenty-five and benefitted immensely from his association with JRD.

'It is hell of a job to be the successor of Ratan … Cyrus had this handicap,' says Prasad Menon, who was selected by Mistry to be the chairman of Vistara. Bhaskar Bhat is sharper and more direct in airing his opinion on why Mistry was not the right person to be appointed as chairman, Tata Sons. He says, 'He [Mistry] is like me; what I mean is that he is like one of us, a manager. We are all good managers. I know how to run a company. I will do all the nuts and bolts and I can ask all the wrong questions. … On the other hand, RNT is a leader who has followers and not a manager who has only subordinates.'

When the soft-spoken N. Chandrasekaran, who succeeded Mistry as chairman, Tata Sons, was asked about what could have been reasonably expected of his predecessor, he is understandably subtle. Chandrasekaran had spent thirty years at TCS, including as its CEO and MD, before becoming chairman. He says, 'It would be unfair to comment … But after induction, grooming over five years in different operating companies would have helped.'

Mistry also started with another handicap. He suddenly found himself sitting atop a huge group of a nationally incomparable size, with over 100 disparate companies, producing a dizzying array of products, from salt to SUVs. He struggled to find his feet in this complex labyrinth, resulting in a mismatch between expectations and the outcomes he could deliver.

Schisms in the Empire

Mistry had quite a lot going for him when he was appointed as chairman. Some aspects of his work style had impressed Ratan during the twelve months Mistry served as deputy chairman. What particularly struck Ratan was the latter's apparent proclivity to analyse issues from different perspectives and take a balanced view. He would say, 'You need to look at one aspect or the other' and that was impressive, Ratan says.

Ratan believed that Mistry and he could have made a great team with 'him on the finance side and me on the operations side'. He reveals that he